

HCL Beanstalk 4455

Powered by a Pentium 4 running at 2.4 GHz, the Beanstalk 4455 has great features for technology enthusiasts, at a reasonable price. The

processor sits on an Intel motherboard based on the D845 chipset and a 533 MHz FSB (front side bus), giving you extreme power to tackle intensive tasks such as editing movies in real-time. The 256 MB DDR-RAM allows for a snappy system response and makes the resource-hungry Windows XP work very smoothly.

The system comes with a 4x AGP slot on which sits an ASUS V8170 Magic (64 MB DDR) graphics card, which provided decent gaming performance. The 16x DVD drive with a slot interface eliminates the tray-jamming problem faced in most DVD drives. Audio is handled by the onboard sound-card coupled with a powerful 30 watt 2.1 speaker system from Altec Lansing. The system provides users with four free PCI slots, six USB ports and a FireWire port (IEEE 1394) that offers blazing transfer rates for the external peripherals. An onboard 10/100 Mbps LAN card is also included.

The machine implements the storage subsystem using IDE RAID-0, which delivers substantially higher performance than a single hard disk.

On the software front, it comes with XP Plus for Windows XP, Norton AntiVirus 2002, Microsoft Encarta Encyclopedia, School Whiz and Multilingual software. Sporting very powerful core components at Rs 59,990, this computer is suited to both, work and play.

Suitability to Task Index

Gaming	6.03
Productivity	7.37
Office apps/Internet	6.24

In terms of system design and construction, the Compaq Presario 3705AP turned out to be the sturdiest. This system had a tool-free casing where thumbscrews were used to make it easy to open the system for troubleshooting or upgrading. It came in classic black and had two USB ports on the front panel to attach USB peripherals conveniently. Another system that had two USB ports on the front panel was the Dart Emerald.

While the Visualan Lavish sported a very large cabinet, its cables were not organised or tied together. Nor did it have any labelled ports on the back panel to indicate which peripheral goes where—a detail that is useful to novices. Interestingly, this system had provision for two USB ports on the front panel of the cabinet, but not the ports themselves. The Visualan Wisdom too had a similar type of cabinet, while the PCS Orion came without labelled ports or organised cables.

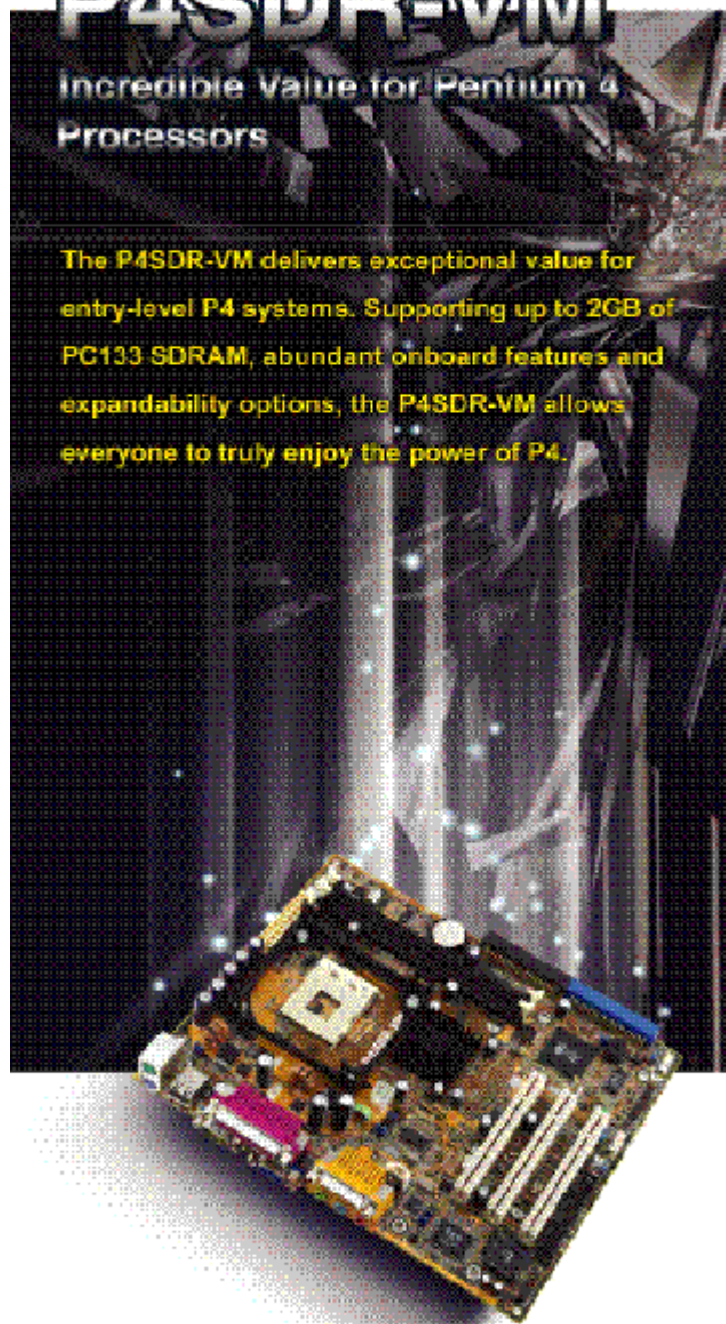
As for the HCL systems, the Beanstalk 4455 featured a very roomy cabinet with adequate airflow. Since the Pioneer 16x DVD drive in this system featured a slot-in disk interface, it is not susceptible to damage like other tray-based CD or DVD drives. The HCL Beanstalk 4458, however, featured a smaller cabinet with unorganised cables. However, this system had two USB ports on the front of the cabinet and a keyboard that included virtually

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